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The Manager's Field Kit

What I'd want on paper the week I inherited a sales team. Ten short chapters and five worksheets.

Before you start

I've taken over a few sales teams that were on fire when I got there. Some I put out. A couple I made worse before I made them better. This is what I'd want on paper the first week, if I had to do it again.

It isn't a methodology. It's the handful of things that held up, and a few worksheets I'd actually use. Read the chapter that matches your week and skip the rest.

The first 30 days

The mistake I made the first time was deciding who was good and who wasn't by the end of week two. I was wrong about two of the five. Now I look at the patch before I look at the person.

If three people have failed in the same territory, I don't have three bad reps. So for each rep I size the territory first: account quality, the installed base, the quota, the comp plan, who had it before and how they did. Some patches can't make the number with anyone in them, and it's better to know that in October than in June.

Then the person, in roughly this order. Do customers want to spend time with them? Is there pipeline that exists only because they're there? When they're in front of a customer, can they sell? Are they still trying? The third one is the one I used to skip, and it's the one that tells you whether you're coaching or managing.

The best hour I spend in the first month is sitting with each rep and going through five of their real deals. I learn more listening to how they talk about the customer than from any dashboard.

And the rep I'd have written off first is often the one who skips the internal meetings and has customers calling back. The one with the spotless CRM and no customer pull is the one I watch.

My rough month: week one, meet everybody and ask what they'd change. Week two, size every patch and write down the ones that can't work. Week three, sit in deals. Week four, tell my boss what I found, patches first.

The weekly rhythm

Two meetings carry most of the week: a one-on-one that's about the rep, and a forecast call that's about the number. When I let them blur together, my one-on-ones turned into status updates and people stopped telling me anything useful.

My one-on-ones run thirty minutes. The rep's list goes first, including whatever I'm doing that's in their way. Then one deal, looked at properly. Then one thing I saw them do and one thing to try next time. I close by reading back what I said I'd do, and then I do it before the next one. That last part built more trust than anything clever I ever said.

The forecast call runs forty-five minutes and covers the number only. Commit first, a minute a deal unless something changed. Best case second. Everything else goes in a note. When the call runs past an hour, it's turned into a pipeline review nobody prepared for, and I'd rather stop and schedule the real one.

Once a month I skip the deal in the one-on-one and ask what they'd do differently if they ran the team. You hear things nobody says in a group.

The forecast call

To me, commit means the customer could tell you today how the money gets to you and when. Short of that it's best case, however sure the rep sounds. Most of the shaky deals I've inherited broke in one of five places, so those are the five I ask about:

QUESTION	WHAT I'M REALLY ASKING
Customer	Has the customer said, in their words, that they want to solve this?
Money	Does the money have a name: a budget line, a program, a fiscal year?
Power	Have we met the person who can make it happen, not just the one who likes us?
Path	Do we know how they'll actually buy it: the vehicle, the contracting office, the approvals?
Now	What makes it happen this period instead of next?

The most useful question I know in a forecast call is "who told you that?" A rep who can name a person and a date has a deal. A rep who says the customer is really excited has a feeling, and I've forecast a few feelings. They don't close.

When I need to move a deal, I don't argue with the rep's read. I ask which of the five they'd defend to my boss, and we forecast that. Nobody loses face, and the number gets honest. On federal deals, path is where things slip most, so I want the contract vehicle and the lead time before anything stays in commit.

Pipeline: enough, and sturdy enough

There are two questions and most reviews only ask the first. Is there enough pipeline? And would what's there survive a bad week?

For the first, coverage is one divided by your win rate. The 3X everybody quotes is a 33% win rate that nobody says out loud. At 20% you need 5X. At 25%, 4X. I use the team's qualified win rate from the last four quarters, and I only count qualified pipeline that's due this period against it.

QUALIFIED WIN RATE	COVERAGE NEEDED
15%	6.7X
20%	5.0X
25%	4.0X
33%	3.0X
40%	2.5X

For the second, I've seen teams at 4X miss the year. The pipeline was two big deals that hadn't moved since spring. So I ask five more things. Would we still make it if the biggest deal slipped a quarter? Has every commit deal changed stage in sixty days? Does every one have a next step on the customer's calendar, not just ours? Is at least half of it due before the last month? Did we create a quarter of it this quarter?

One habit that helped: I write the forecast without the biggest deal. That's the plan I'm actually running. And the day before a review I move anything that hasn't changed stage in sixty days back a stage. The reps who argue are the ones with information.

Your boss

In my experience the boss doesn't want more information. They want fewer surprises. I send one page a week, same shape every time: the number (commit, best case, the gap), what changed and why, the one thing most likely to cost us the number and what I'm doing about it,

and one ask with a date, or "nothing this week."

I lead with the bad news. A boss who hears it from me early, with a plan attached, starts trusting my forecast. A boss who finds it in the CRM starts checking my work.

When the number from above doesn't match what I can see from below, I don't fight the target. I show the arithmetic: the patches, the coverage at our real win rate, and what it would take to close the gap. The most expensive sentence I ever said to a boss was "we'll find a way." I spent the whole year defending it.

When a rep is struggling

Before I write anybody up, I try to figure out which of four problems I've got. From the dashboard they all look the same.

WHAT IT IS	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	WHAT I DO
The situation	Good rep, bad patch, number or plan	Fix the territory, the quota or the plan. A write-up fixes none of those.
A skill gap	Working hard, not converting	Coach it, one deal at a time, sitting in the room.
An effort gap	Can sell, isn't	Expectations in writing, with dates, and an honest talk about whether they still want this.
The wrong rep	Can't, and has stopped trying, in a fair patch	Start the process. Waiting doesn't make it kinder.

I check the situation first, every time. I once spent six months coaching a rep whose territory couldn't have produced the number for anybody. That's six months I'd like back, and so would he.

The quickest way I've found to tell skill from effort is to watch them with a customer. Good in the room and thin pipeline is usually effort. Working hard and the room goes flat is usually skill.

Review season

In calibration, the room can't see your rep's year. All it can test is your case. I've watched good reps with thin cases lose to average reps whose managers brought receipts.

So I bring five things. Three results from the year, each with a number. For the biggest one, what wouldn't have happened without them. Why it was work at their level and not good work a level down. One real example for each behavior I'm going to claim. And the harder thing I'd give them next year, with a reason I'm sure they can carry it.

Before the room, I check myself. How much of my opinion comes from the last sixty days? Would I think the same if they weren't in my meetings every week? Take away their best win, then their worst month. Does my view hold?

I say the weakest part of the case first. Once the room sees you name your own soft spot, they stop hunting for it. And I keep a running note per rep from January on: date, what happened, the number. November goes a lot easier.

Mistakes I've made so you don't have to

- **Managing the dashboard.** The fields got cleaner. The pipeline didn't get bigger.
- **Saving deals myself.** It worked once. After that the rep waited for me.
- **Reporting the average.** Two reps at 6X and two at 1X isn't a team at 3.5X. It's two problems.
- **Forecasting confidence.** Some people sound sure about everything. That's a personality, not a close date.
- **Sitting on bad news.** I waited until I had a fix. My boss would have rather had the news Monday and the fix Friday.
- **Giving everybody the same one-on-one.** My best rep and my newest rep needed different things from the same thirty minutes.
- **Approving the discount.** The deal's real problem was power. The discount fixed price, which wasn't the problem.

Lines that have worked for me

WHEN	WHAT I SAY
A rep is sure about a shaky deal	"Walk me through who told you that, and when."
Moving a deal out of commit	"Which of the five would you defend to my boss? Let's forecast that."
A rep is missing and I don't know why	"Before we talk about the number, what's in your way?"
A number from above I can't see	"I can commit to this with what I have. Here's what it would take to get to that."
Bad news for my boss	"Heads up before it hits the CRM: this is at risk, here's why, here's what I'm doing."
A rep wants a discount to close	"What does the customer give us for it? A date, more scope, a reference?"
Starting a hard talk	"Here's what good looks like in thirty days. Let's talk about getting there."
I don't know the answer	"I don't know. I'll find out by Thursday." Then I find out by Thursday.

Worksheets

One-on-one

Rep _____ Date _____

Their list: what's in their way, including me

One deal: customer, money, power, path, now

One thing I saw them do, one thing to try

What I said I'd do, and by when

Deal inspection

Deal _____ Rep _____ Date _____

QUESTION	YES / SORT OF / NO	WHO SAID SO, AND WHEN
Customer: have they said they want to solve this?		
Money: does it have a name and a fiscal year?		
Power: have we met who can make it happen?		
Path: do we know the vehicle and the approvals?		
Now: what makes it happen this period?		

I only call it commit with five answers I'd defend to my boss.

Rep diagnostic

Rep _____ Date _____

IN THIS ORDER	YES / SORT OF / NO	NOTES
Patch: could a good rep make this number here?		
Customers: do they want time with this rep?		
Pipeline: is there pipeline only this rep created?		
Craft: can they sell in the room?		
Will: are they still trying to win?		

Patch no: fix the situation. Craft no: coach. Will no: manage. Both no in a fair patch: the wrong rep.

Team pipeline

Quarter _____ Date _____

REP	NUMBER	QUALIFIED PIPELINE	WIN RATE	COVERAGE NEEDED (1 ÷ WIN RATE)	COVERAGE NOW	BIGGEST DEAL AS % OF NUMBER

Anyone whose biggest deal is over a third of their number is one slip from missing.

Calibration case

Rep _____ Level _____ Date _____

Three results, each with a number

Without them, what wouldn't have happened?

Why this was their level, not the one below

One example per behavior I'll claim

The harder thing next year, and why I'm sure

The weakest part of this case, said first

If the kit isn't enough

I'm Mark. I carried a number, managed the people who did, and led partner sales teams at AWS. If you're sitting in one of these right now and want a second set of eyes, I'm glad to talk. Twenty minutes, free, no deck, no pitch.

If I don't think I can help, I'll tell you.

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